
MORNING EDITION · LIFE AFTER 55 · SPECIAL EDITION 2026

GOLDEN HORIZONS

Caribbean coast — where \$1,800/month funds a life most Americans only dream about 🌊

The 2026 Retirement Abroad Starter Kit

Where your Social Security stretches further — and what to check before you move.

Each day, Golden Horizons delivers one carefully researched story about the world's most rewarding places to retire — the real costs, the honest trade-offs, and the practical path to getting there. This guide is your starting point. Everything you need to know. Nothing you don't.

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Before You Read: Three Things to Do

1. Compare your budget

Go to Section 1 first. Find your monthly Social Security income in the affordability table. That tells you instantly which tier of countries is realistic for you.

2. Shortlist 2–3 countries

Read Section 2 (Top 5 Countries) and Section 3 (Visa Cheat Sheet). Pick the 2 or 3 that feel most aligned with your budget, health needs, and lifestyle. Don't try to pick one yet.

3. Plan a trial visit

Section 4 explains the 10 questions every retiree should ask. The last question is the most important: have you done a trial run? Most people know within 30 days.

 Visa rules, income thresholds, and costs change frequently. Always verify with official government sources and consult qualified professionals before making any decisions.

START HERE

What is your guaranteed monthly income?

(Social Security + any pension combined)

Write it down. Then turn to Section 1.

EDITOR'S NOTE

The Question Everyone Is Asking

You've probably wondered: "Is retiring abroad actually realistic for someone like me?"

Most people who ask that question are sitting on a Social Security check of \$1,500 to \$3,000 a month — and watching it barely cover rent, groceries, and a car payment here in the US.

Here's what most people don't know: that same monthly check can fund a genuinely comfortable — even luxurious — life in dozens of countries around the world.

"The same \$2,000 a month that barely covers rent in Ohio funds a full, comfortable life in Colombia, Ecuador, or Thailand."

— Golden Horizons · 2026 Retirement Abroad Starter Kit

This guide is your starting point. It won't overwhelm you. It will show you exactly what's possible — and give you the tools to take the next step at your own pace.



Medellín, Colombia · El Poblado at golden hour — perpetual 75°F, one of Latin America's lowest visa thresholds

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The Reality Check

What Does Your Social Security Actually Buy Abroad?

The table below shows what a single person can expect at common Social Security income levels. These are mid-range estimates — not rock bottom, not luxury. Actual costs vary by lifestyle and inflation.

MONTHLY SS INCOME	TIER	WHAT YOU CAN AFFORD
\$1,200 / month	BUDGET	Comfortable single life in Vietnam, Albania, Ecuador, or Bolivia
\$1,800 / month	COMFORTABLE	Comfortable single life in Colombia, Thailand, Philippines, Paraguay
\$2,500 / month	STRONG	Single or modest couple in Panama, Costa Rica, Portugal, Greece
\$3,500+ / month	PREMIUM	Comfortable couple life almost anywhere on this list

For couples, add roughly 40–60% to single estimates. Two people sharing rent, utilities, and groceries is far more efficient than two separate budgets.

THE SIMPLE AFFORDABILITY TEST

Step 1: Write down your guaranteed monthly income (Social Security + any pension).

Step 2: Find your number in the table above.

Step 3: If your income matches even the first row — you have real options.



Cuenca, Ecuador · UNESCO World Heritage city — 60°F year-round, \$400/month rent

Compare all 20 countries → golden-horizons.org/destinations

Top 5 Countries Under \$2,000/Month

Real Options for Real Budgets

These five countries offer a comfortable single-person lifestyle for under \$2,000/month. All accept US Social Security as qualifying visa income in most cases.

 *Visa rules, income thresholds, and costs change frequently. Always verify with official government sources and consult qualified professionals before making any decisions.*

#1 — Ecuador

LATIN AMERICA · USD ECONOMY · FASTEST CITIZENSHIP

Cuenca, Ecuador · The city of eternal spring — 60°F year-round, rent from \$400/month

BEST FOR	Retirees who want a USD economy, perfect climate, and a path to citizenship in ~3 years
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,200–\$1,500/month (single)
VISA SHORTCUT	\$1,446/mo (3× SBU of \$482) · SS accepted · Online application · Citizenship ~3 years
WATCH OUT FOR	<i>Security concerns in coastal cities — Cuenca remains safe. Spanish essential. Good private hospitals in Cuenca (Hospital Universitario del Río, Santa Inés); specialized care may require Quito.</i>
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	<i>The single best value destination in the Americas for budget retirees seeking a perfect climate and USD simplicity.</i>

MONTHLY BUDGET ESTIMATE

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
1-BR Apartment (Cuenca)	\$400–\$600
Groceries	\$200–\$300
Dining Out (3–4×/week)	\$150–\$200

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
Private Health Insurance	\$100–\$150
Utilities + Internet	\$80–\$100
Everything Else	\$200–\$300
TOTAL / MONTH (Single)	~\$1,500

Full country guide → golden-horizons.org/destinations

#2 — Colombia — Medellín

SOUTH AMERICA · ETERNAL SPRING · JCI HOSPITALS

Medellín, Colombia · El Poblado at golden hour — perpetual 75°F, JCI-accredited hospitals

BEST FOR	Couples on a tight-to-moderate budget seeking world-class healthcare and vibrant expat life
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,500–\$2,200/month (couple)
VISA SHORTCUT	~\$1,350–\$1,400/mo (3× SMMLV) · SS accepted with apostilled letter · Online, 2–4 weeks · Mandatory comprehensive private health insurance required
WATCH OUT FOR	<i>Research specific neighborhoods. El Poblado and Laureles are safe. Mandatory private health insurance adds ~\$200–\$350/month for a couple.</i>
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	<i>Excellent overall value for couples. JCI-accredited hospitals (Hospital Pablo Tobón Uribe, Clínica Las Américas) at 40–70% below US costs. Eternal 75°F spring.</i>

MONTHLY BUDGET ESTIMATE

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
2-BR Apartment (couple)	\$700–\$950
Groceries	\$300–\$400
Dining Out	\$200–\$300

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
Health Insurance (2 people)	\$200–\$350
Utilities + Internet	\$80–\$120
Everything Else	\$250–\$350
TOTAL / MONTH (Couple)	~\$1,800–\$2,200

Full country guide → golden-horizons.org/destinations

#3 — Vietnam — Da Nang

SE ASIA · LOWEST COST OF ALL 20 COUNTRIES

Da Nang, Vietnam · The Han River at dusk — \$1,200/month total budget, world-class street food

BEST FOR	Ultra-budget retirees who want the most purchasing power anywhere in Asia
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,000–\$1,400/month (single)
VISA SHORTCUT	No income requirement · 90-day e-visa (\$25) · Renewable annually · No dedicated retirement visa
WATCH OUT FOR	<i>IMPORTANT: Verify SS payment eligibility for Vietnam residents with SSA at ssa.gov before committing — restrictions may apply. Good private hospitals for routine care; major procedures may require travel.</i>
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	<i>The most affordable quality-of-life destination in the world. Extraordinary food. Fast fiber internet. Lowest overall cost.</i>

MONTHLY BUDGET ESTIMATE

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
1-BR Apartment	\$350–\$500
Groceries	\$120–\$180
Dining Out (meals from \$2–\$8)	\$100–\$180
Private Health Insurance	\$80–\$120

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
Utilities + Internet	\$60–\$90
Everything Else	\$150–\$250
TOTAL / MONTH (Single)	~\$1,200

Full country guide → golden-horizons.org/destinations



#4 — Albania

EUROPE · CHEAPEST EU-ADJACENT OPTION · 1-YEAR VISA-FREE

Albanian Riviera · Ionian coast — Europe's most affordable coastline, 1-year visa-free for Americans

BEST FOR	Retirees who want European scenery and lifestyle without European prices
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$900–\$1,300/month (single)
VISA SHORTCUT	~\$1,000–\$1,200/mo guideline · 1-year visa-free entry for Americans · Apply in-country for longer stays · Citizenship path ~5 years
WATCH OUT FOR	<i>No US-Albania tax treaty — potential double taxation risk, consult a US expat tax specialist. Healthcare is limited outside Tirana; private clinics recommended.</i>
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	<i>Europe's cheapest option with a coastline that rivals Greece. The 1-year visa-free entry makes it ideal for an extended trial visit.</i>

MONTHLY BUDGET ESTIMATE

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
1-BR Apartment (sea view)	\$250–\$450
Groceries	\$120–\$200
Dining Out	\$80–\$160
Private Health Insurance	\$80–\$140
Utilities + Internet	\$60–\$100

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
Everything Else	\$150–\$250
TOTAL / MONTH (Single)	~\$1,100

Full country guide → golden-horizons.org/destinations



#5 — Paraguay

SOUTH AMERICA · ZERO FOREIGN INCOME TAX · CITIZENSHIP IN ~5 YEARS

Asunción, Paraguay · Colonial streets — zero tax on all foreign income, permanent residency in ~2 years

BEST FOR	Tax-minimizers seeking the fastest and most affordable residency path in South America
MONTHLY ESTIMATE	~\$1,000–\$1,400/month (single)
VISA SHORTCUT	~\$1,300/mo recommended · SS accepted · Local lawyer helpful (~\$800–\$1,500) · No minimum stay requirement · Permanent residency in ~2 years
WATCH OUT FOR	<i>Spanish essential. Small English-speaking community. Limited healthcare infrastructure outside Asunción — use private clinics.</i>
GOLDEN HORIZONS VERDICT	<i>Best for tax minimization. Zero Paraguayan tax on all foreign income. Fast, flexible residency path. Dual citizenship retained.</i>

MONTHLY BUDGET ESTIMATE

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
1-BR Apartment (Asunción)	\$300–\$500
Groceries	\$150–\$220
Dining Out	\$100–\$180
Private Health Insurance	\$80–\$140
Utilities + Internet	\$70–\$110
Everything Else	\$150–\$250

EXPENSE	ESTIMATE
TOTAL / MONTH (Single)	~\$1,200

 Panama City, Panama · Bay of Panama at dusk — immediate permanent residency, USD economy, Pensionado discounts

Compare all 20 countries → golden-horizons.org/destinations

The Visa Cheat Sheet

One Top Pick From Every Region

Five countries — one from each major retirement region — with key visa facts at a glance. Full 20-country comparison at golden-horizons.org/destinations

 *Visa rules, income thresholds, and costs change frequently. Always verify with official government sources and consult qualified professionals before making any decisions.*

REGION & COUNTRY	MIN. INCOME	PROCESSING	SS ACCEPTED	TAX ON SS	PATH TO PR
 Panama Latin America	\$1,000/mo	4–6 months		 None	 Immediate
 Portugal Europe	€920/mo	3–6 months		 Complex	 5 years
 Thailand SE Asia	~\$1,825/mo	2–4 weeks		 2024	 Difficult
 Belize Caribbean	\$2,000/mo	1–3 months		 None	 QRP only
 Colombia S. America	~\$1,400/mo	2–4 weeks		 (5 yrs)	 5 years

Key:  Favorable ·  Partial / Complex ·  Not applicable. Note: Thailand's 2024 tax changes may affect remitted foreign income — consult a tax specialist.

"Colombia's ~\$1,400/month pension visa is one of the lowest thresholds in Latin America — and it fully accepts US Social Security with proper documentation."

— Golden Horizons · 2026 Visa Analysis



Explore all 20 destinations → golden-horizons.org/destinations

10 Questions to Ask Before You Go

The Questions Most People Forget Until It's Too Late

Retiring abroad is one of the best decisions many Americans make. These 10 questions will save you from the most common surprises.

1. Can I receive my Social Security in this country?

The SSA restricts payments to residents of certain countries — Vietnam and Cuba among them. Check the official SSA restricted country list at ssa.gov before making any plans.

2. What if I get seriously ill?

Know in advance where you would go for cardiac surgery, cancer treatment, or a serious accident. Most destinations in this guide have good JCI-accredited private hospitals for routine and moderate care (e.g., Medellín, Bangkok, Panama City). Budget for international health insurance with evacuation coverage (\$100–\$250/month) and know your nearest major medical center.

3. Do I need a lawyer or local agent?

Panama, Colombia, and others benefit greatly from professional help. Budget \$500–\$2,000 for immigration assistance — money very well spent. Paraguay specifically benefits from a local immigration lawyer to navigate the process.

4. What about US taxes?

You do not stop owing US federal income taxes when you move abroad. Americans are taxed on worldwide income regardless of where they live. Hire a US expat tax specialist before you leave — not after. This is critical.

5. What happens to my Medicare?

Medicare does not cover you outside the United States (with very rare exceptions). Most countries in this guide offer excellent private insurance for \$100–\$250/month per person — often with faster specialist access than you have now.



Chiang Mai, Thailand · World's #1 expat city — world-class hospitals at 50–70% below US cost

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6. Can I bring my medications?

Most common US prescriptions are available internationally — often significantly cheaper, sometimes without a prescription. Some medications are restricted or controlled. Check for any medications you take regularly before committing to a country.

7. How will I manage my money?

Consider a Charles Schwab checking account (refunds all ATM fees globally) or Wise for international transfers. USD-economy countries — Panama, Ecuador, Belize — are the simplest for Americans. For others, set up a local bank account early in your visa process.

8. What is the minimum stay requirement?

Some visas require you to be in the country for a minimum number of days per year or you lose your status. Panama requires just 1 day per year. Colombia requires you not be absent more than 180 consecutive days. Know the rules before spending 3 months visiting family in the US.

9. How will I stay connected to family?

Video calls are free. Flights from most retirement destinations to the US cost \$300–\$700 round-trip. Panama and Mexico offer the shortest return flights from the eastern US. Build the visit budget into your annual plan — most expats fly home 1–2 times per year.

10. Have I done a trial run?

The single best thing you can do is spend 1–3 months in a country on a tourist visa first. Rent an apartment — don't stay in a hotel. Shop at local markets. Use local transport. Visit the private hospital. You will know within 30 days whether it is the right fit for you. Most people do.



Cuenca, Ecuador · Morning at the flower market — \$200/month groceries, \$1,500 total single budget

Your 3-Step Next Move

A Simple Roadmap From Curious to Committed

Most people spend 6–18 months going from "I'm curious" to "I'm going." Here's how to use that time wisely.

MONTH 1	Pick 3 Countries	Use the affordability table in Section 1. Read the 5 country profiles. Pick 2–3 that fit your income, health needs, and lifestyle. Don't try to commit yet.
MONTHS 2–3	Compare Visas + Healthcare	For each shortlisted country: verify the current visa income requirement at the official government site, identify the nearest JCI-accredited private hospital, and price comprehensive international health insurance.
MONTHS 4–6	Book a Trial Visit	Spend 4–8 weeks in your top country on a tourist visa. Rent an apartment. Shop at local markets. Visit the private hospital. You will know within 30 days whether it's right for you.

"The trial visit is the most important step. Most people know within 30 days whether a country is right for them."

— Golden Horizons · Retirement Planning Guide



Da Nang, Vietnam · A quiet morning on the beach — \$1,200/month total budget including rent

Start exploring today → golden-horizons.org

Your Next Step

You Don't Have to Figure This Out Alone

Every day, Golden Horizons sends one short email covering a real retirement destination — the costs, the visa, the lifestyle, and the honest trade-offs. No hype. No pressure. Just the information you need to make a good decision at your own pace.

The newsletter is free. Unsubscribe any time.

"I had no idea Colombia was so affordable. I booked a trial visit after reading three issues."

— Golden Horizons subscriber

"The visa cheat sheet alone was worth subscribing. I finally understood what I actually qualify for."

— Golden Horizons subscriber

Welcome to Golden Horizons.

The dream of retiring somewhere warm, affordable, and beautiful is more realistic than you think — and we'll show you exactly how.

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